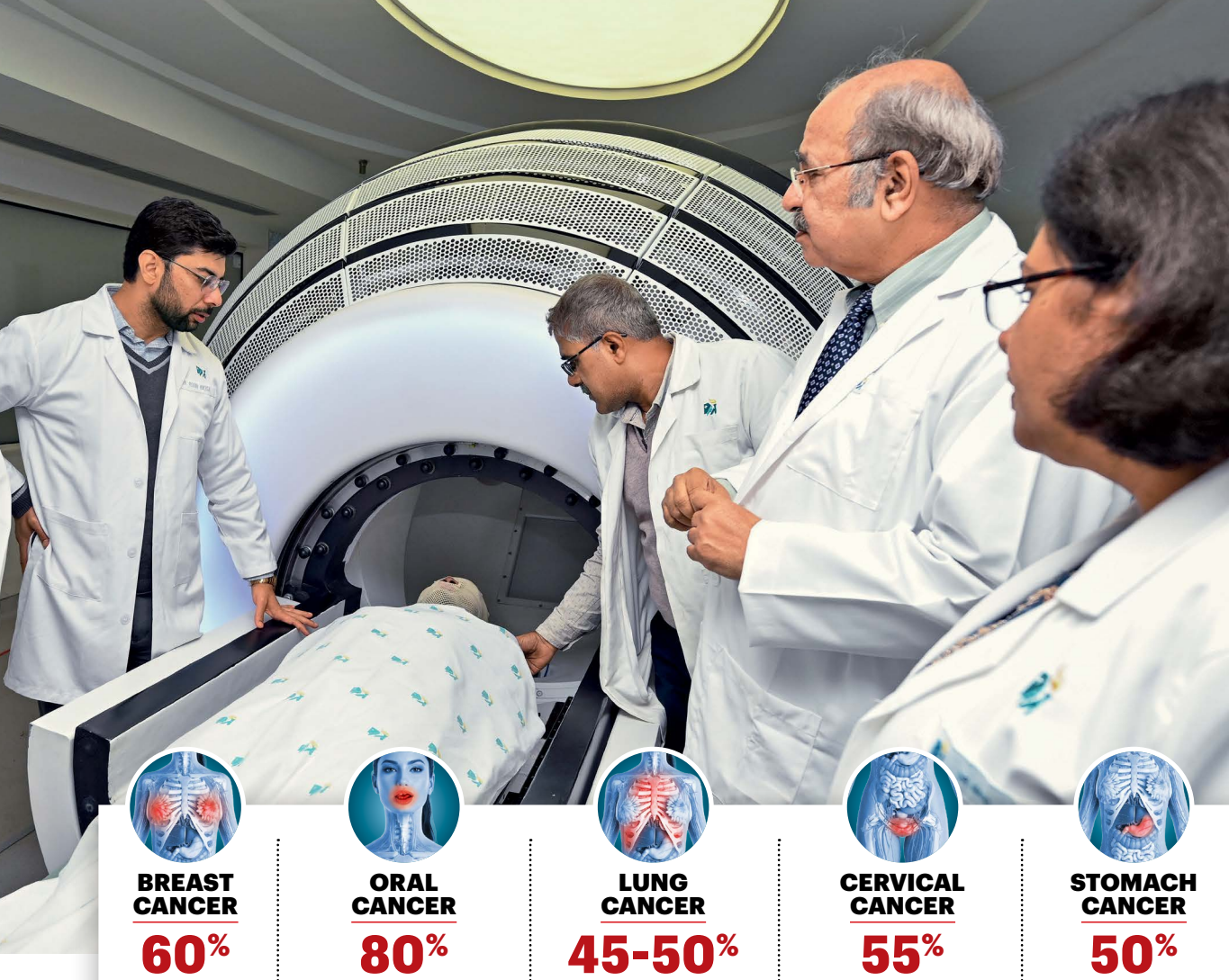


BREAST CANCER

60%

present at Stage III–IV

ORAL CANCER

80%

reach hospitals at advanced stage

LUNG CANCER

45-50%

are metastatic at first hospital visit

CERVICAL CANCER

55%

present at Stage III or higher

STOMACH CANCER

50%

are diagnosed at Stage III–IV

oral cancer has an 80–90 per cent five-year survival rate, late diagnosis reduces this to 50–60 per cent. Lung cancer outcomes are even worse. A 2025 multi-hospital cohort study from Kerala found a median survival of just 8.6 months for metastatic lung cancer, with nearly 58 per cent of patients dying within a year.

Why are cancers diagnosed late?

Doctors say late diagnoses are not incidental, they are embedded in the way patients seek care and how the system responds. Dr Anil Heroor, director of Oncological Sciences at KIMS Hospitals, Thane, explains that cancer rarely begins with dramatic symptoms. "The biggest challenge is that cancer symptoms are usually subtle: a small painless lump in the breast or rectal bleeding that resembles piles. Patients frequently ignore them, assuming they will get resolved on their own," he says. Even when patients visit a doctor, symptoms are often treated without structured evaluation. "Research shows there is at least a four-month gap between the first symptom and an accurate diagnosis, leading to valuable time being lost while the disease progresses," adds Dr Heroor.

Dr Raajit Chanana, director of Medical Oncology at Dharamshila Narayana Hospital in Delhi, describes the breakdown more starkly. The delays begin at home, continue in primary care, and are compounded by systemic bottlenecks. "Imaging slots are weeks away. Biopsies are delayed due to cost or fear. Pathology reports take time. Financial constraints add another layer of paraly-

CANCER AND ITS STAGES

STAGE 0: Abnormal cells exist but have not spread. This is very early cancer, detected often only through advanced imaging

STAGE 1: Small tumour, localised in the organ of origin

STAGE 2: Cancer that may have spread to nearby tissue or lymph nodes

STAGE 3: Cancer that has advanced into adjacent tissue and lymph nodes

STAGE 4: Metastatic cancer, or cancer that has spread from the original organ—breast, lung, colon, prostate or stomach—to bones, lungs, liver, lymph nodes or brain